

ETHICAL CONSIDERATIONS IN RESEARCH

COMM50 Postgraduate Study & Research Methods

Defining Ethics



Webster's collegiate dictionary defines ethics as:

'the discipline dealing with what is good and bad and with moral duty and obligation'

Ethics vs. Morals

(<http://www.diffen.com/difference/>)

	Ethics	Morals
<i>What are they?</i>	The rules of conduct recognized in respect to a particular class of human actions or a particular group or culture.	Principles or habits with respect to right or wrong conduct. While morals also prescribe dos and don'ts, morality is ultimately a personal compass of right and wrong.
<i>Where do they come from?</i>	Social system - External	Individual - Internal
<i>Why we do it?</i>	Because society says it is the right thing to do.	Because we believe in something being right or wrong.
<i>Flexibility</i>	Ethics are dependent on others for definition. They tend to be consistent within a certain context, but can vary between contexts.	Usually consistent, although can change if an individual's beliefs change.
<i>The "Gray"</i>	A person strictly following Ethical Principles may not have any Morals at all. Likewise, one could violate Ethical Principles within a given system of rules in order to maintain Moral integrity.	A Moral Person although perhaps bound by a higher covenant, may choose to follow a code of ethics as it would apply to a system. "Make it fit"
<i>Origin</i>	Greek word "ethos" meaning "character"	Latin word "mos" meaning "custom"
<i>Acceptability</i>	Ethics are governed by professional and legal guidelines within a particular time and place	Morality transcends cultural norms

Ten Ethically Questionable Practices



1. Involving people without their knowledge or consent
2. Coercing them to participate
3. Withholding information about the true nature of the research
4. Otherwise deceiving the participant
5. Inducing participants to commit acts diminishing their self-esteem

Ten Ethically Questionable Practices



6. Violating rights of self-determination
7. Exposing participant to physical or mental stress
8. Invading privacy
9. Withholding benefits from some participants (comparison groups)
10. Not treating participants fairly, or with respect

Philosophies of Ethics



□ *Deontology*

- ▣ Concerned with duties and rights
- ▣ It's wrong to kill even if it means saving the lives of others

□ *Consequentialism*

- ▣ Concerned with the value of the consequences of actions
- ▣ If the action means more lives are saved, then it must be right

A Trivial Example



Source: <https://www.mcdonalds.com/us/en-us/new-big-mac.html>

A Trivial Example

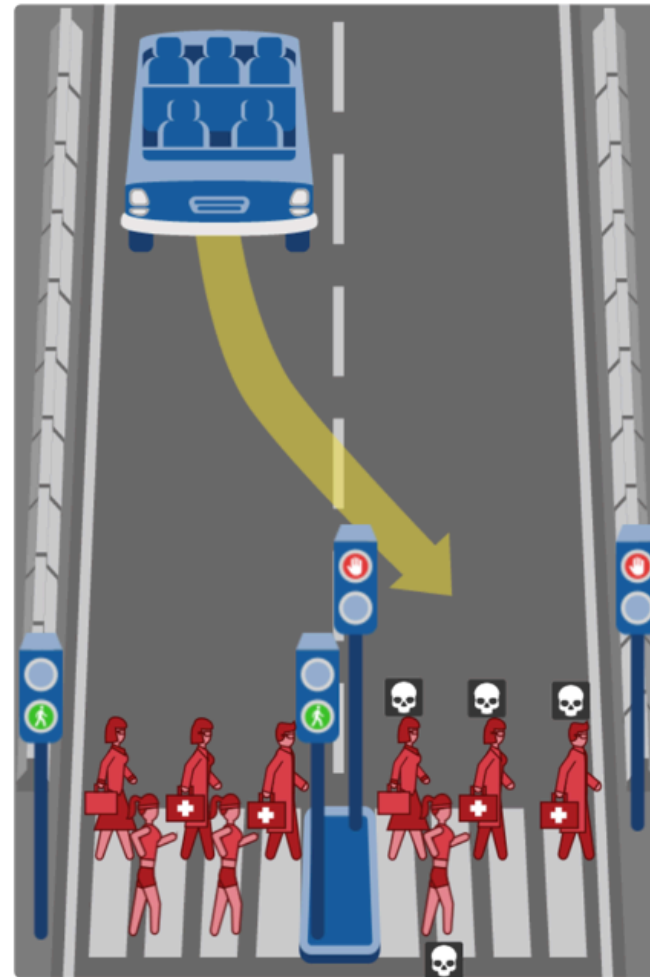
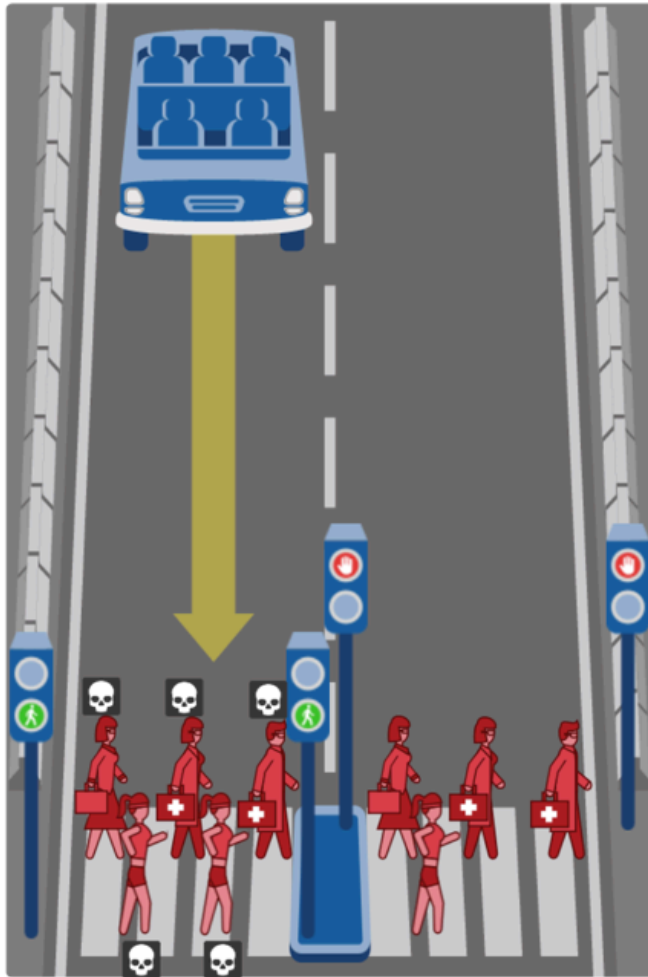


Source: <http://dht.seriouscats.com/archives/2009/04/mcdonalds.html>

A Less Trivial Example



An Interactive Ethical 'Game'

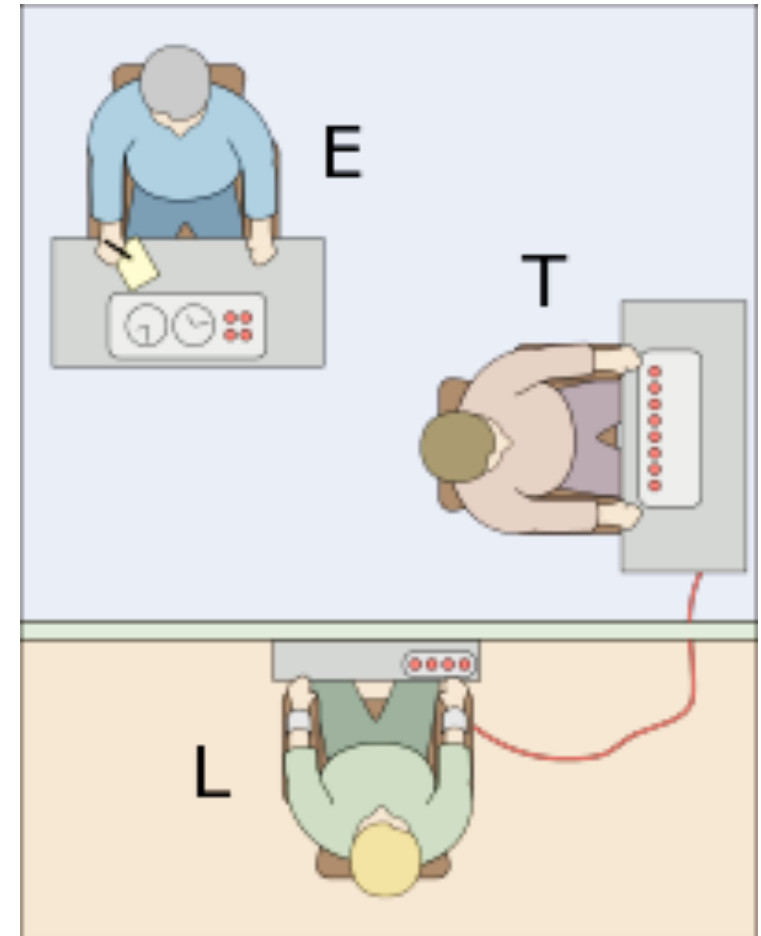


<http://moralmachine.mit.edu>

The Milgram Experiment



- An experiment in obedience in the 1960's
 - ▣ Experimenter (E)
 - ▣ Teacher (T)
 - ▣ Learner / Student (L)
- Presented as an experiment about negative reinforcement in learning
- Learners received electric shocks from Teacher when giving an incorrect answer. Voltage increased each time.
- The Experimenter and Learner were actors. Real participants given the Teacher role
 - ▣ The Learner never received any shocks
- Was, and remains, ethically questionable



Source: https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Milgram_experiment

The Milgram Experiment



Modern recreation of the experiment on *The Heist*, Channel 4, 4th January 2006, UK

The Milgram Experiment

- *What ethical issues can you identify in the experiment?*
 - ▣ Deception
 - ▣ Coercion
 - ▣ Psychological discomfort / distress
- *Were these justified?*
- *How could they be mitigated and still conduct the research?*

The Milgram Experiment

- Original 1960's Documentary

- ▣ <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=wdUu3u9Web4>



Ethical Challenges (Andrews 1989)

1. Family, school, and church can no longer be relied upon to undertake the development of moral persons. “Moral exhortation and oral piety are offensive. The need for cooperation among people with different beliefs [as well as different cultural backgrounds] diminishes discussion of religion and related ethical issues.”
2. Self-interest, competition, and careerism tend to erode moral imperatives in the lives of persons. “Under pressure to get ahead, the individual (of whose native integrity we are hopeful) is tempted to pursue advancement at the expense of others, to cut corners, to seek to win at all costs, to make things seem better than they are.”
3. “Making ethical decisions is easy when the facts are clear and the choices black and white. But it is a different story when the situation is clouded by ambiguity, incomplete information, and conflicting responsibilities.”
4. “This existential resolution requires the would-be moral individual to be the final authority in a situation where conflicting ethical principles are joined. It does not rule out prior consultation with others or the recognition that, in a hierarchical organization, you might be overruled.”

Ethical Challenges (Andrews 1989)

5. “Ethical decisions therefore require of individuals three qualities that can be identified and developed. The first is competence to recognize ethical issues and to think through the consequences of alternative resolutions. The second is self-confidence to seek out different points of view and then to decide what is right at a given time and place, in a particular set of relationships and circumstances. The third is what William James called the tough-mindedness to make decisions when all that needs to be known can not be known or when the questions that press for answers have no established or incontrovertible solutions.”

6. “Codes of ethics are now commonplace. But in and of themselves they are not effective. The most pervasive problems cannot be foreseen, nor can the proper procedures be spelled out in advance to tell the person on the line what to do.” In difficult situations, it is necessary to make a leap from general policy [principles, precepts, beliefs] to situationally specific action.”

7. “To generalize the ethical aspects of a business decision, leaving behind the concrete particulars that make it real, is too often to sermonize, to simplify, or to rationalize away the plain fact that many instances of competing ethical claims have no satisfactory solutions.”

Ethics in Research

- Ethical concerns emerge as you plan your research
- In context of research, ethics refers to the appropriateness of your behaviour in relation to the rights of those who become the subject of our work, or are affected by it
- We must conduct research projects in line with ethical principles
- Seek out and adhere to ethical frameworks and guidelines
 - ▣ They are designed to safeguard everyone involved: participants, researchers, institutions, and society

Ethics in Research



- Following a code of ethics will provide you with a statement of principles and procedures for the conduct of your research
- You may be required to submit your research proposal to a research ethics committee
- You may need ethical approval to carry out your research

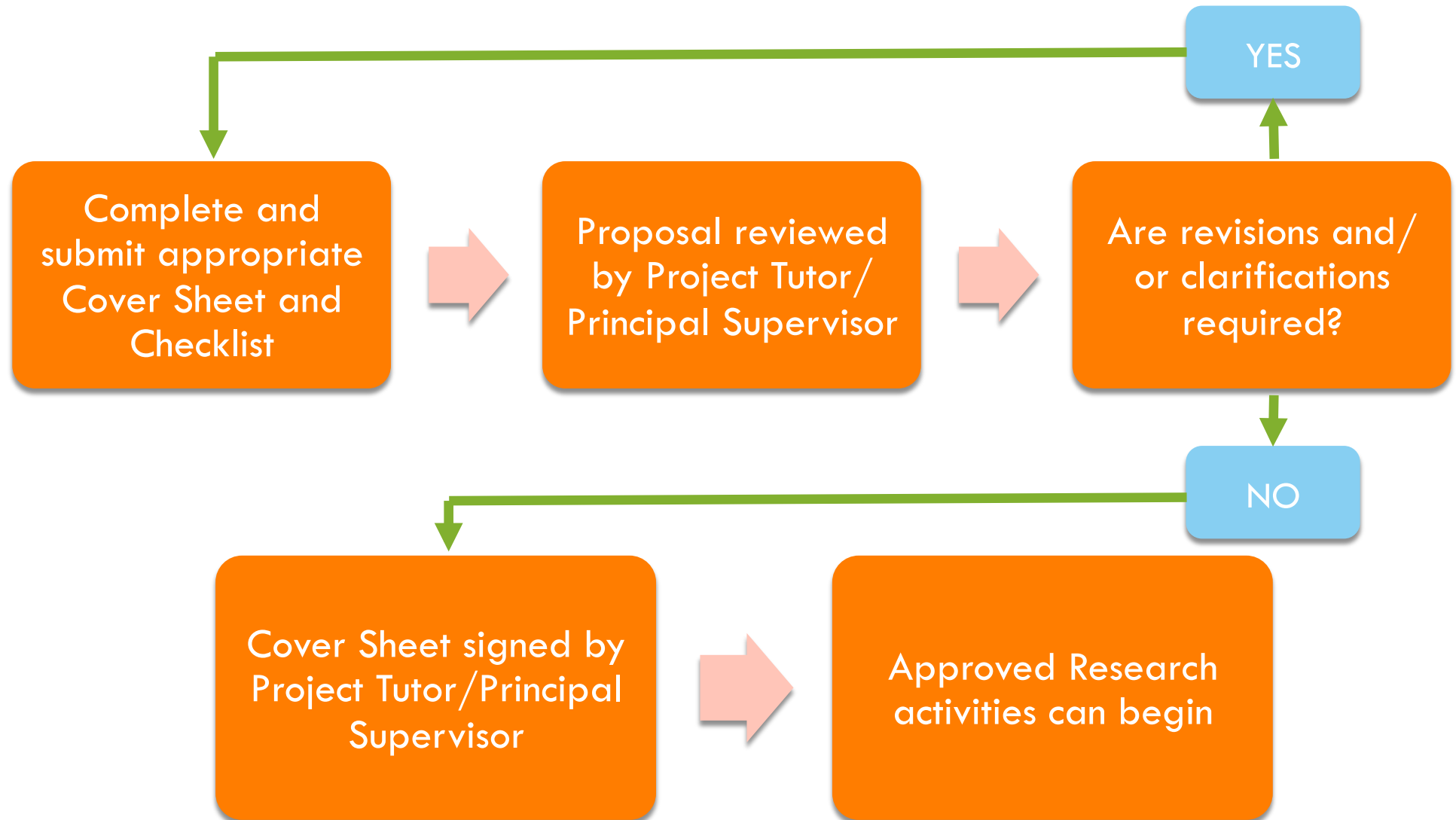
Ensuring High Ethical Standards (Salkind 2013)

1. Consider using simulation as an alternative
2. In cases where harm is unavoidable, try to locate a population that has already been exposed
3. Always secure informed consent
4. When possible publish group, rather than individual data
5. If you suspect participation could have negative impact, use a small sample size
6. Ask a colleague to review your proposal, particularly the methodology
7. Make use of an institutional review board (or ethics committee), whenever appropriate

WGU Ethics Procedure

- *All research projects must have ethical approval before primary data collection / experimental work begins [see RESC Guidance for details. If in doubt, speak to your project tutor, principal supervisor or Head of University Research Centre]. There are 3 routes for review and approval:*
 1. *RESC (Research Ethics Sub-Committee) - for staff and postgraduate research student proposals involving human subjects; all research involving animals, and all research requiring formal external approval*
 2. *Staff and postgraduate research students Low Risk research*
 3. *Research done by undergraduate and taught Masters students*

WGU Ethics Procedure: Taught Students



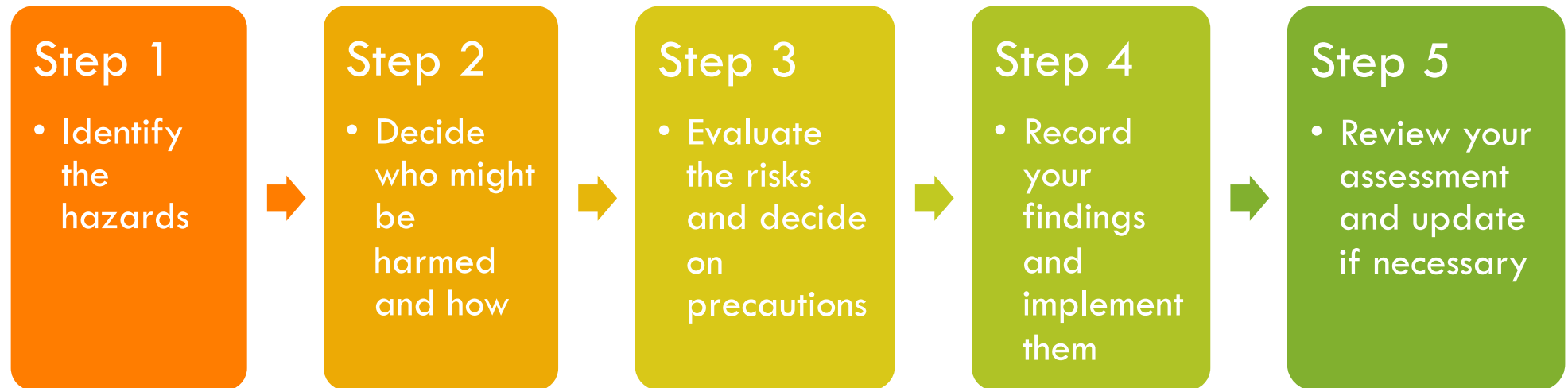
Ethical approval of research projects in taught programmes – Standard Questions (Y/N)

1. Does the research comply with the University's Code of Practice on Ethical Standards for Research?
2. Does this research comply with the requirements of any relevant professional body's code of conduct?
3. Has a suitable and sufficient risk assessment been carried out (including potential harm to the researcher)?
4. Will the study require the co-operation of a 'gatekeeper' for initial permission / access to the people, animals, places, data, or other resources required for the research?
5. Does this research require the formal approval of an external body ?

Ethical approval of research projects in taught programmes – Standard Questions (Y/N)

6. Could the research have an impact on people living or working in the immediate locality?
7. Will anyone other than the researcher (the applicant) and the research supervisor (if relevant) have access to the raw data produced by the research?
8. Is there a sponsor?
9. Is there a collaborating organisation?
10. Will any research be undertaken outside UK legal jurisdiction?
11. Will your research involve investigation of or engagement with terrorist or violent extremist groups?

Risk Assessment



WGU Ethics Procedure – Code of Practice



“DO NO HARM (non-maleficence) and, if possible, DO GOOD (beneficence). Consideration of risks versus benefits must be weighed up by researchers.”

Testing Out Learning of Ethics



kahoot.it

References

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- Robson, C. and McCartan, K., 2016. *Real world research*. John Wiley & Sons.
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